

Fiji



A volcanic archipelago in the South Pacific, with two large islands and 880 islets. Tensions between native Fijians and the Indian minority have sparked a succession of coups.



GEOGRAPHY

Main islands are mountainous, fringed by coral reefs. Remainder are limestone and coral formations.



CLIMATE

Tropical. High temperatures all year round. Cyclones are a hazard.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The British introduced workers from India in the late 19th century, and by 1946 their descendants outnumbered the indigenous Fijian population. Ethnic-Fijian nationalism is strong. Many Indo-Fijians left after the 1987 coup, restoring ethnic Fijians to a majority. In 2000, the first Indian-dominated government was ousted. The army led another coup in 2006. Women are lobbying for more rights.

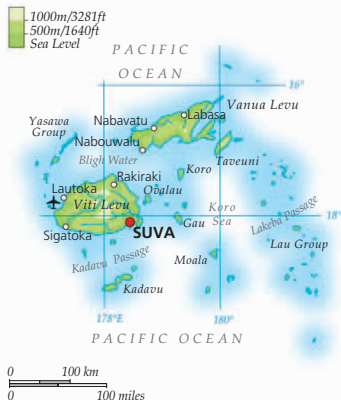


INSIGHT: Both Fijians and Indians practice fire-walking; Indians walk on hot embers, Fijians on heated stones



THE ECONOMY

Tourism was main sector, though damaged by instability. Coups have also caused international isolation. All sectors struggling: sugar production, gold mining, textiles, timber, and commercial fishing.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of the Fiji Islands

DATE OF FORMATION: 1970

CAPITAL: Suva

POPULATION: 849,200

TOTAL AREA: 7054 sq. miles
(18,270 sq. km)

DENSITY: 120 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Fijian, English*, Hindi, Urdu, Tamil, Telugu

RELIGIONS: Hindu 38%, Methodist 37%, Catholic 9%, Muslim 8%, other 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Melanesian (Fijian) 51%, Indian 44%, other 5%

GOVERNMENT: Transitional regime

CURRENCY: Fiji dollar = 100 cents